equation turned out to be correct. And further still, the theory contends that space moves like the surface of the sea. The effects of these ‘gravitational waves’ are observed in the sky on binary stars, and correspond to the predictions of the theory even to the astonishing precision of one part to one hundred billion. And so forth.

In short, the theory describes a colourful and amazing world where universes explode, space collapses into bottomless holes, time sags and slows near a planet, and the unbounded extensions of interstellar space ripple and sway like the surface of the sea … And all of this, which emerged gradually from my mice-gnawed book, was not a tale told by an idiot in a fit of lunacy, or a hallucination caused by Calabria’s burning Mediterranean sun and its dazzling sea. It was reality.

Or better, a glimpse of reality, a little less veiled than our blurred and banal everyday view of it. A reality which seems to be made of the same stuff which our dreams are made of, but which is nevertheless more real than our clouded quotidian dreaming.

All of this is the result of an elementary intuition: that space and gravitational field are the same thing. And of a simple equation which I cannot resist giving here, even though you will almost certainly not be able to decipher it. Perhaps anyone reading this will still be able to appreciate its wonderful simplicity:

$$R_{ab} - \tfrac{1}{2} R\, g_{ab} = T_{ab}$$

That’s it.

You would, of course, need to study and digest Riemann’s mathematics in order to master the technique to read and use this equation. It takes a little commitment and effort. But less than is necessary to come to appreciate the rarefied beauty of a late Beethoven string quartet. In both cases the reward is sheer beauty, and new eyes with which to see the world.